



Unveiling Community Histories: Geospatial Insights into Jackson Ward's Neighborhood Identity and Boundary

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JACKSON WARD

- Jackson Ward is one of the most historic neighborhoods in the entire United States being the center of Black Capitalism and the “Harlem of the South”
- Consolidated Bank & Trust, originally known as St. Luke’s Penny Savings Bank, was the oldest surviving black-operated bank in the United States (1903-2005)
- The Leigh Street Armory, the first African American militia base in the country built in the 1890s, has been repurposed into the Black History Museum and Culture Center of Virginia

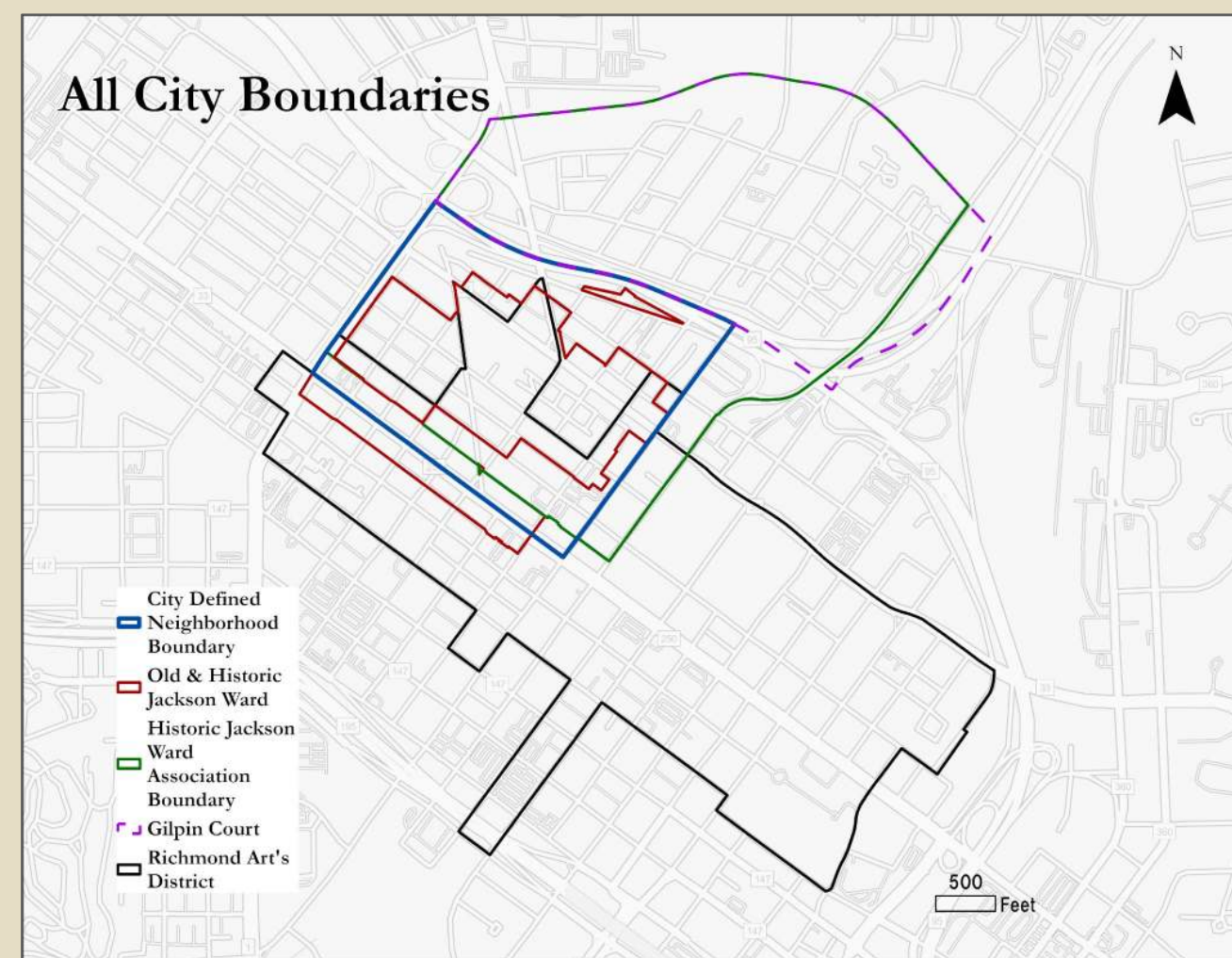


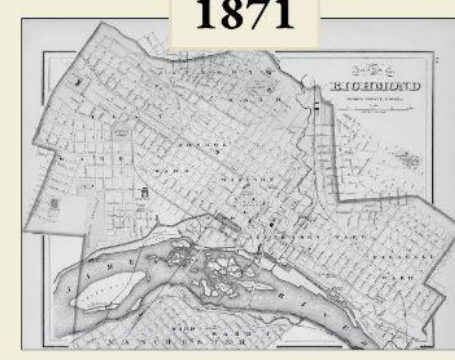
Figure 1. Overlap of all administrative and historical boundaries in Jackson Ward

- Historical events and systemic racism have led to debate on the boundaries of Jackson Ward
- Lack of agreement on boundaries has delayed decisions on improving and preserving the historic neighborhood
- Shrinking, divided, and uncertain boundaries in Jackson Ward have been caused by historical complexities, systemic racism, and differing cultural values

Jackson Ward Timeline

Jackson Ward Established

Jackson Ward was originally established as a gerrymandered voting ward meant to limit the political power of African American voters.



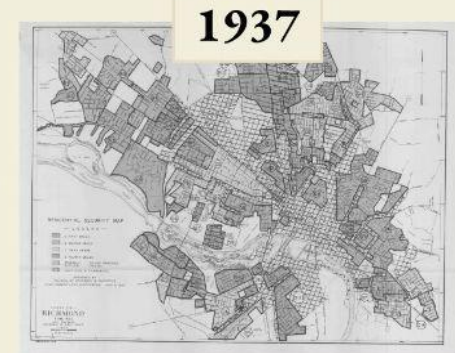
True Reformer's Bank Opens

W.W. Browne's monumental True Reformer's Bank kicked off the 'heyday' of Jackson Ward, the birthplace of black capitalism in America.



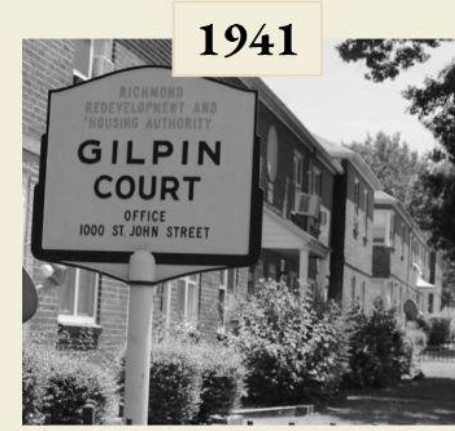
Redlining

In 1937, HOLC redlining practices deemed Jackson Ward “hazardous” due to its high minority population, rendering it ineligible for Federal Housing Administration benefits.



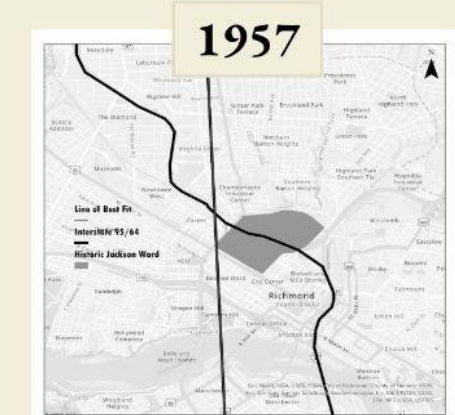
Gilpin Court Built

Public Housing projects often targeted black communities. Gilpin Court was a public housing project built in Jackson Ward, creating a new dynamic and splitting the neighborhood.



I-95 Construction

The interstate's planned route threatened to disrupt a predominantly white area, leading city officials to alter the path to cut through Jackson Ward, effectively splitting it in two.



METHODS

- Data collection instrument used for this research is Survey123, a product by the Environmental Science Research Institute (ESRI)
- IRB-approved researchers gathered responses in Jackson Ward from June 1, 2024, to June 28, 2024

SURVEY QUESTIONS

1. Jackson Ward residential status
2. Members of the community
3. Years of residency
4. Connection on a scale of 1-5
5. Businesses, places, or organizations
6. Participatory map
7. Age range
8. Racial and ethnic backgrounds

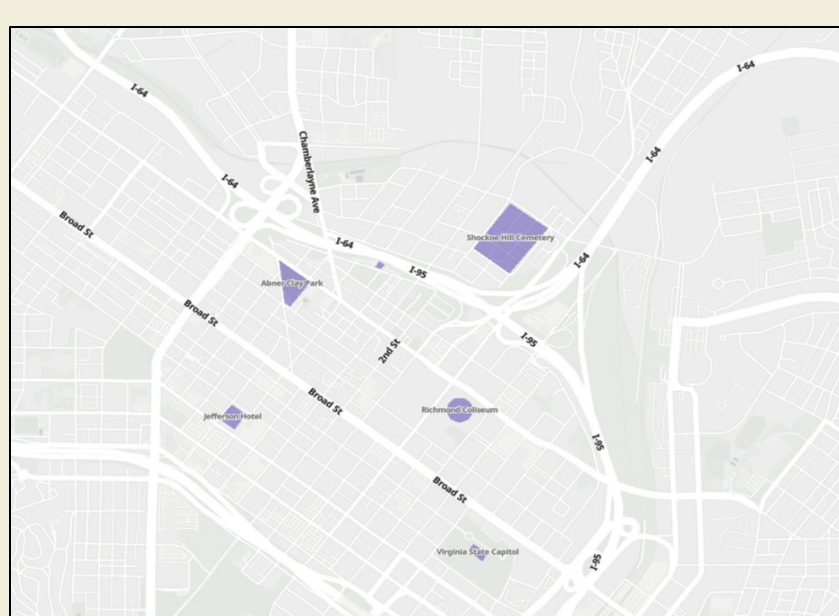


Figure 2. Map interface for participatory mapping

POLYGON CAPTURE

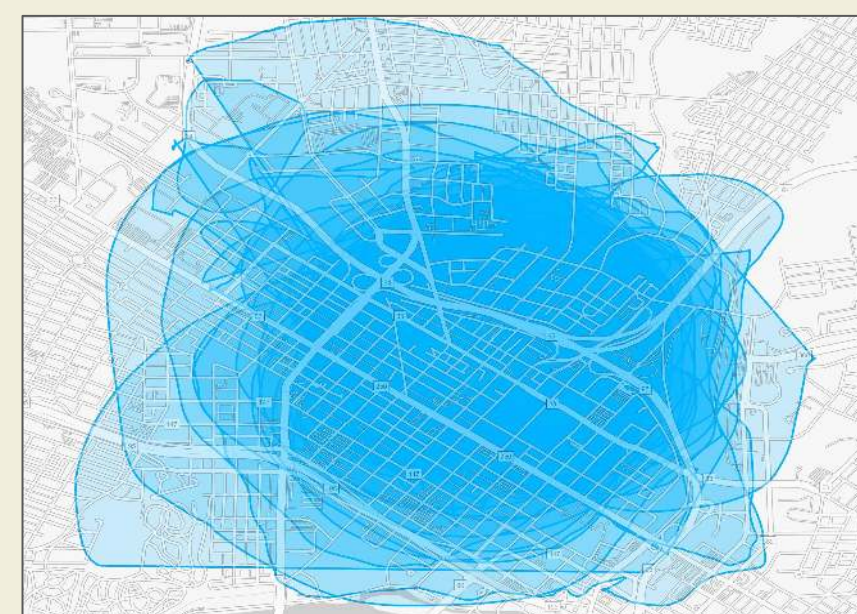


Figure 3. All 133 polygons captured by participants

- Each participant was asked to draw their perceptual boundary of Jackson Ward
- These polygons were then processed for the analysis
- Through ArcGIS Pro overlap percentage was calculated and displayed

Collect polygons through participatory mapping tool

Export features

Split the polygons by transforming the features to polygons

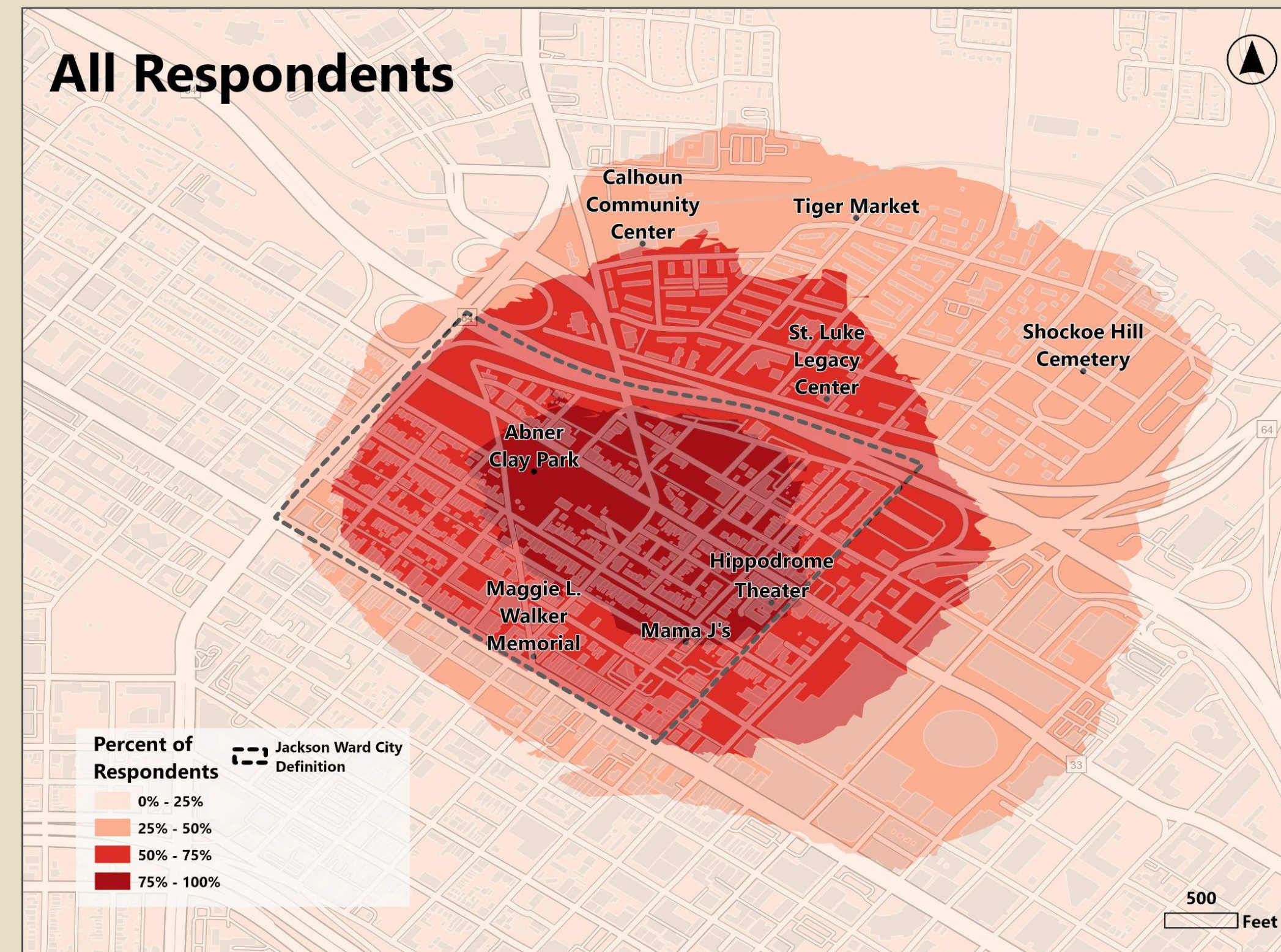
Add spatial join between the original features and the split polygons

Use match option “within” to calculate the polygon overlap based on join counts

Calculate the percentage overlap based on the “within” join counts

RESULTS

All Respondents



- Total Respondents: 133 individuals participated in the analysis
- Perception of Boundaries:
 - ◆ Jackson Ward and Interstate: 60%-80% of respondents believe Jackson Ward crosses over the interstate
 - ◆ Extent of Jackson Ward: 60%-80% of respondents feel Jackson Ward extends past 2nd Street
- Perception vs. Definition: Jackson Ward is perceived to be larger than its official defined administrative boundaries
- Maps Provided: Demographic breakdowns based on survey responses are illustrated in accompanying maps

Figure 4. Percent agreement overlay of all 133 respondents

AGE GROUP

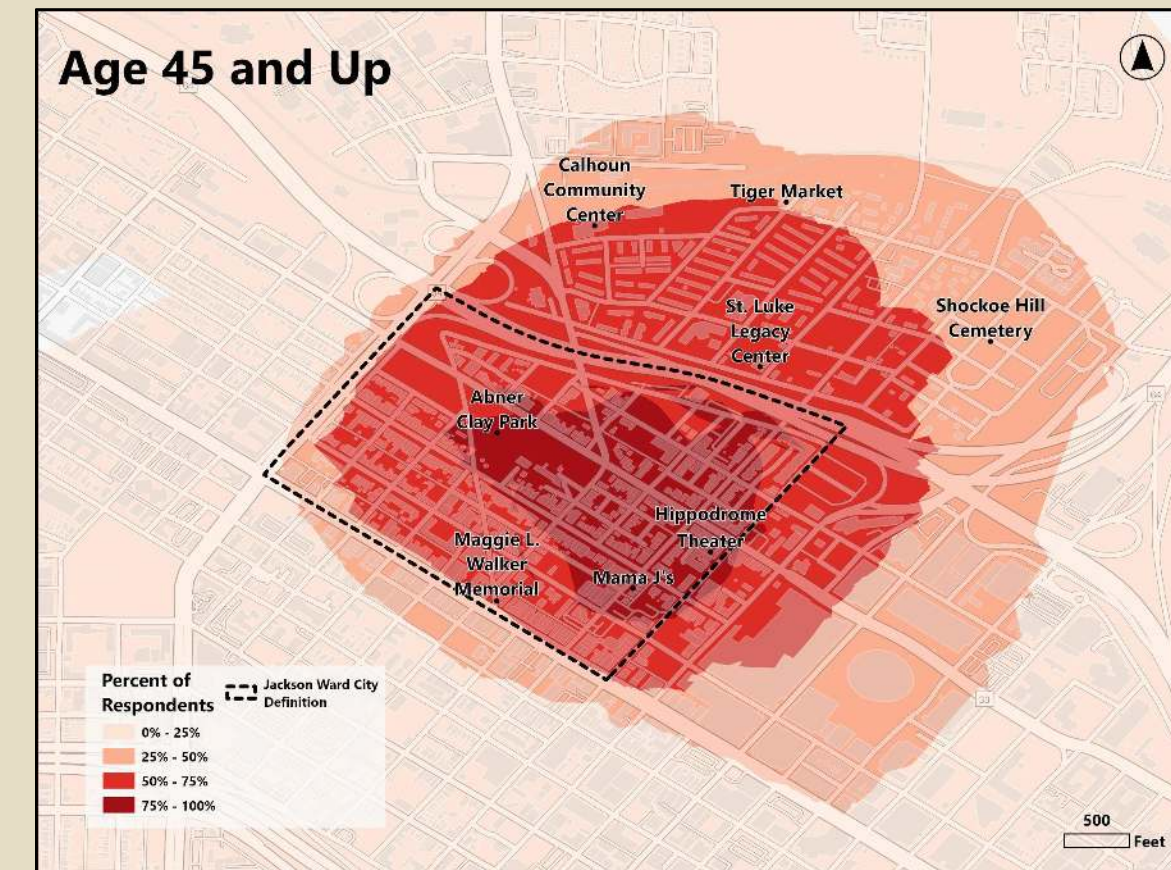


Figure 5. Percent agreement overlay of respondents ages 45+

- 63 respondents said they were 45+ and 65 respondents said they were 30 and under
- Between the two age groups the younger generation often restricts the boundaries to the south of the interstate
- 80%-100% of respondents ages 45+ highlight 2nd street
- 80%-100% of respondents 30 and under highlight more on Abner Clay park area

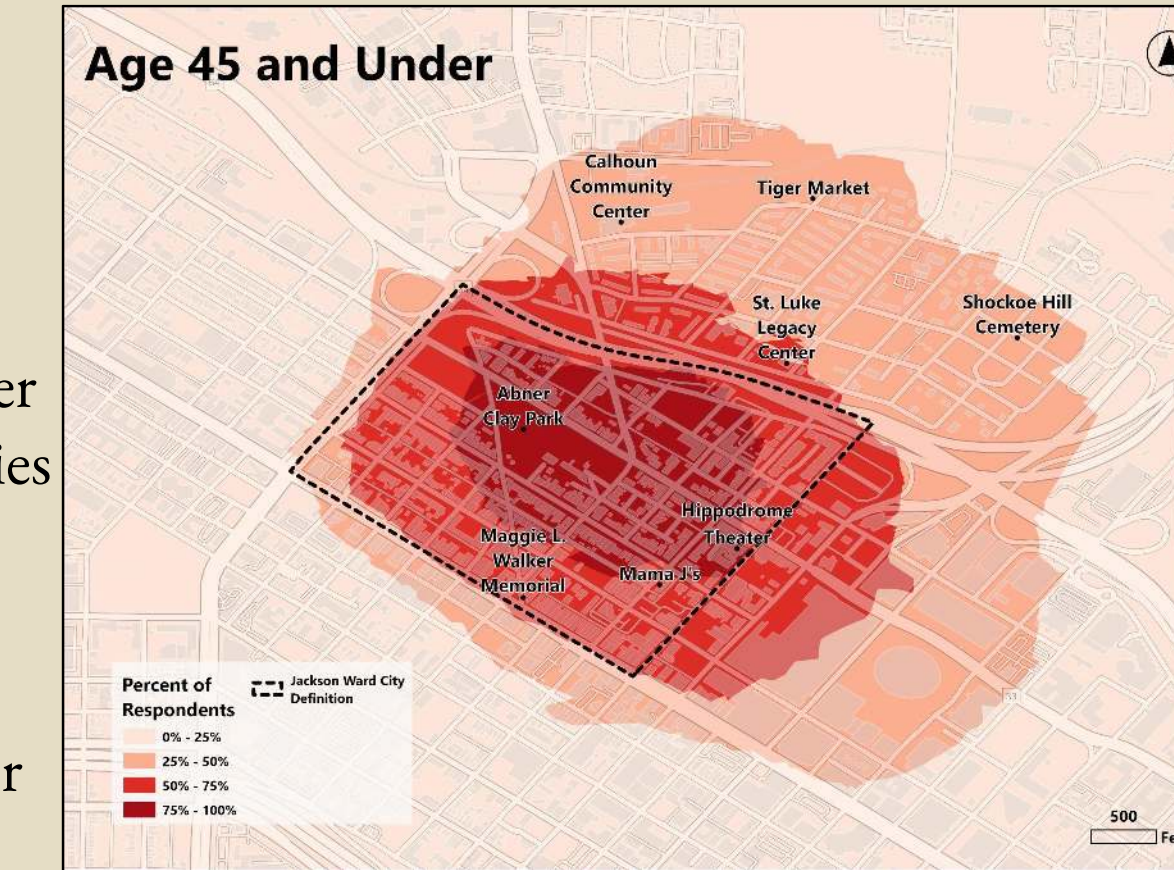


Figure 6. Percent agreement overlay of respondents ages 30 and under

RESIDENT STATUS

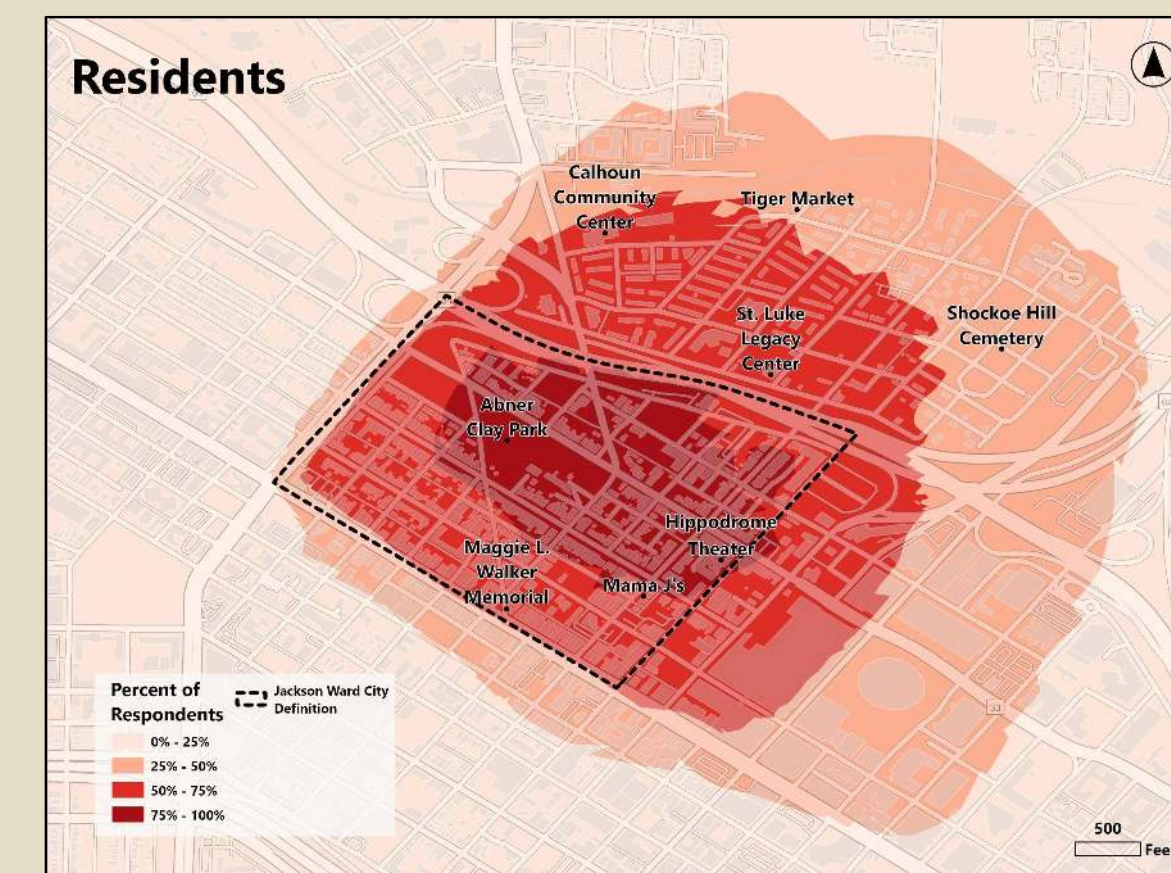


Figure 7. Percent agreement overlay who are residents

- 60 respondents said that they currently live in Jackson Ward and 73 respondents said they do not live in Jackson Ward
- In both respondent groups 60%+ said that Jackson Ward extends past the interstate, covering St. Luke's Building and 2nd street
- 80%-100% of resident respondents say the Hippodrome is within Jackson Ward

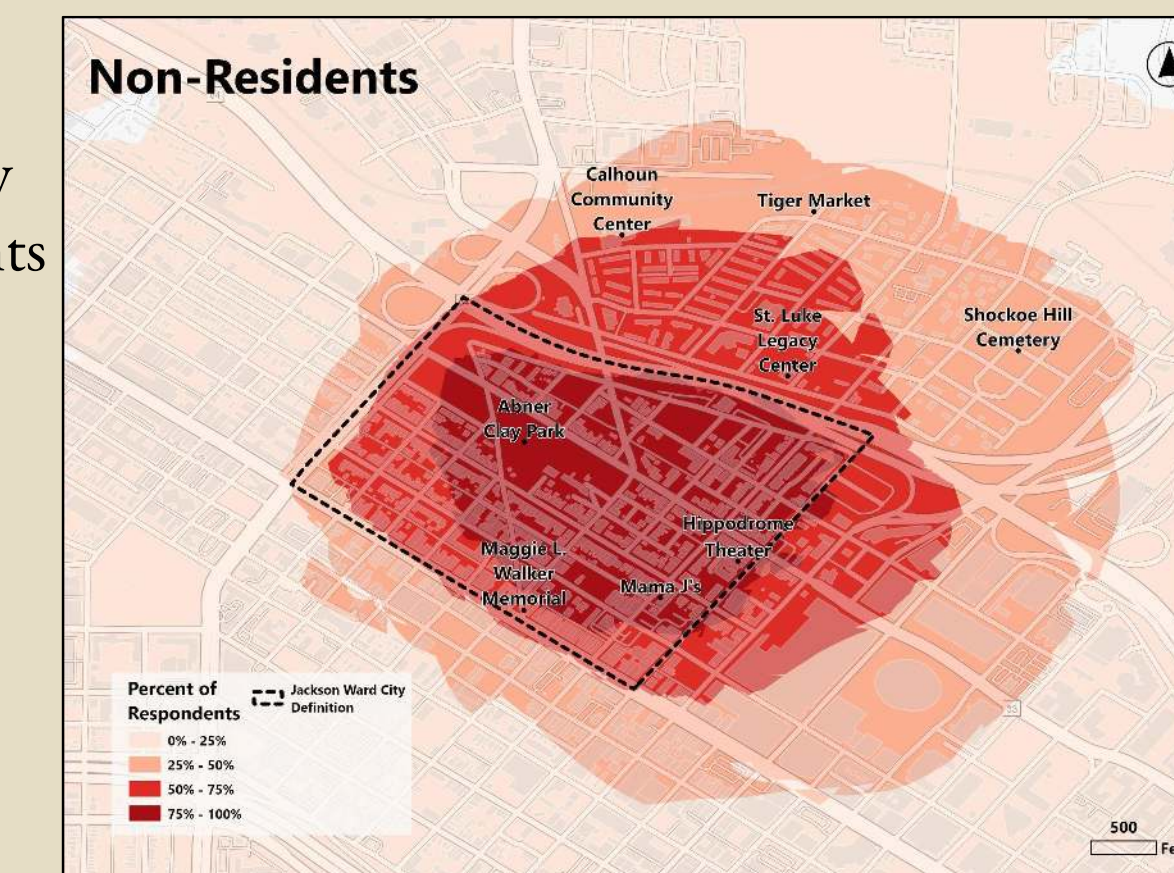


Figure 8. Percent agreement overlay of respondents who are non-residents

CONNECTIVITY RATING

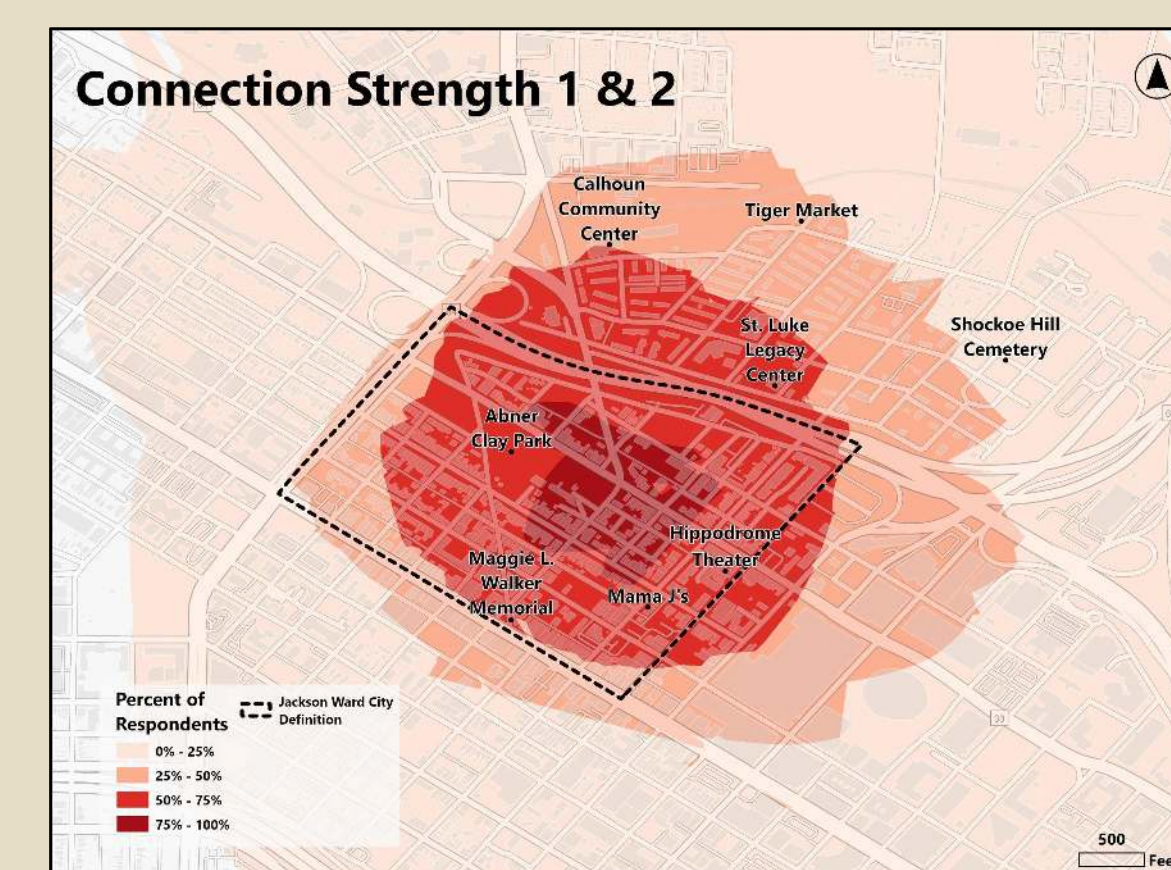


Figure 9. Percent agreement overlay of respondents with connection 1 & 2

- 78 respondents said that they would rate their connection to Jackson Ward a 4 or 5 while 33 respondents rated their connection a 1 or 2
- 60%+ of all respondents agreed that Jackson Ward crossed the interstate and included key historical landmarks like the St. Luke's Building
- 40%+ of respondents with a connection strength of 4 & 5 said that Shockoe Hill Cemetery is a part of Jackson Ward

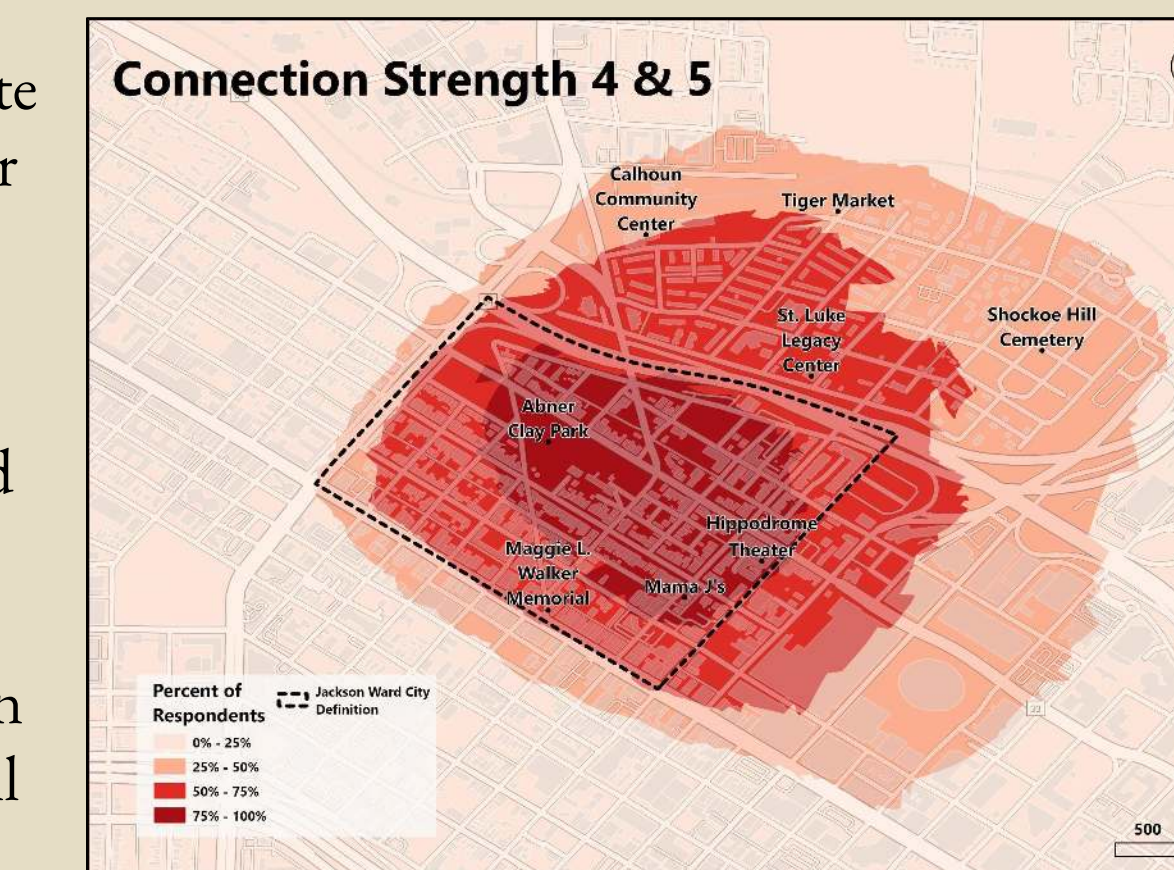
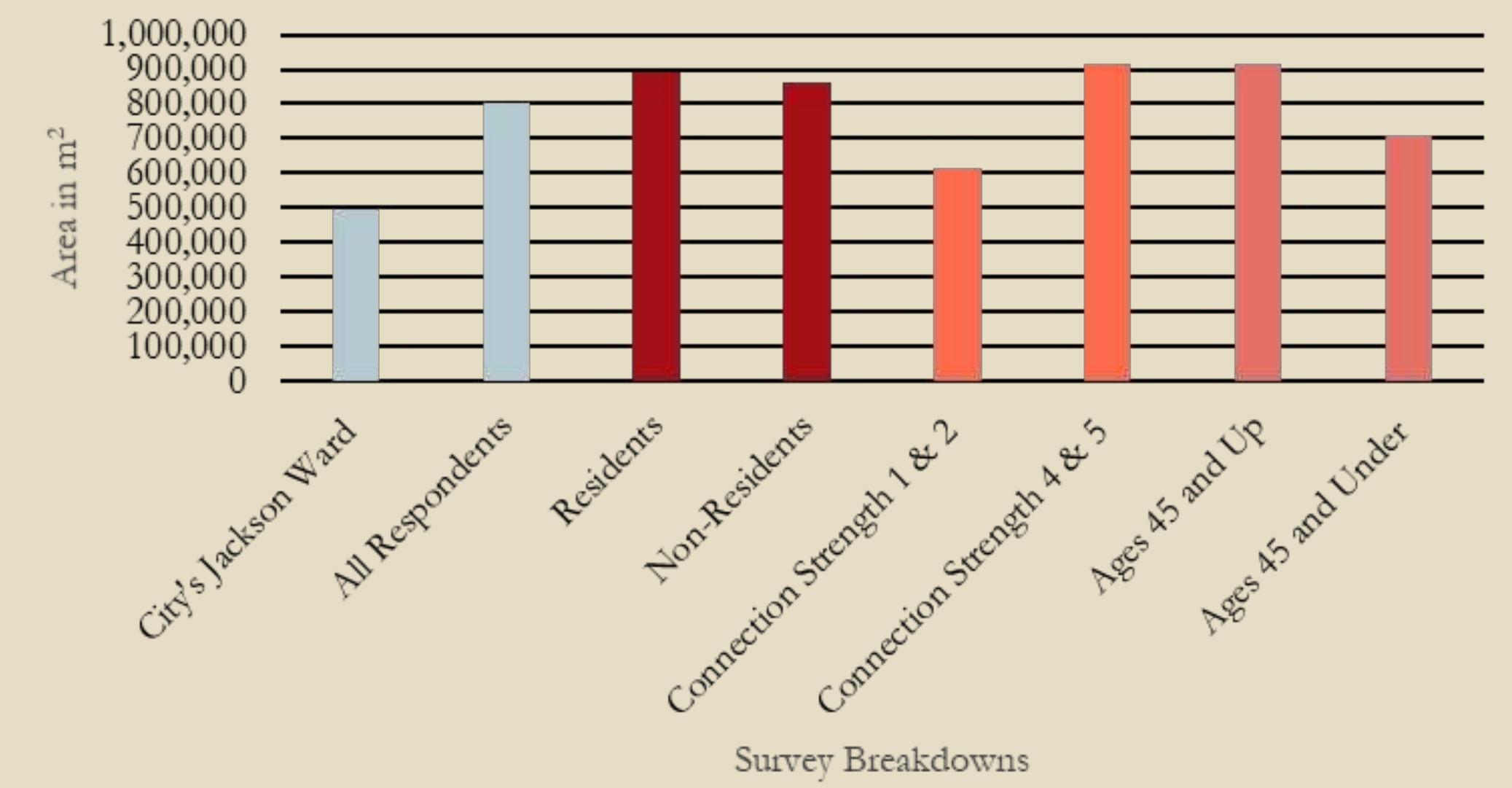


Figure 10. Percent agreement overlay of respondents with connection 4 & 5

ANALYSIS

BOUNDARY AREA (m²)



- All breakdowns of the data with 50% or more agreement had a significantly larger area compared to the City of Richmond's Jackson Ward definition
- The calculated area from residents, connection strength 4 & 5 and ages 45 and up all nearly doubled the area of the City of Richmond's Jackson Ward definition
- Connection strength and age group had the largest discrepancies in area, however all groups still said that Jackson Ward was larger than the City's administrative boundary



Figure 11. Most frequently mentioned establishments

- One of the most impactful businesses being Mama Js, a family owned southern and soul food restaurant opened in 2009
- Many respondents identified key historic sites within the neighborhood; Maggie Walker House, Black History Museum, The Hippodrome, etc.
- Sites North of the interstate like the Corner Store, Tiger Mart, and the Calhoun Center were frequently mentioned

MOVING FORWARD

Future Directions

- Improving the quality of the survey demographic questions
 - ◆ Add a question for gender identity to the survey
 - ◆ Add more categories to the community connection question such as siblings, children, and/or cousins
- Expand on the polygon capture by having respondents draw neighborhoods in close proximity (i.e. delineate Gilpin Court vs Jackson Ward)
- **Community Contribution Goals**
- Bring more awareness to the damages caused to the Jackson Ward community through the division, shrinking, and marginalization of the historic neighborhood
- Support for different administrative boundaries changing to include and preserve fundamental historic sites north of the interstate such as St. Luke's Legacy Building

Community Partner

The Historic Jackson Ward Association is committed to developing awareness of Jackson Ward history as well as integrating history into the modern day experience of the neighborhood. To learn more, visit <https://www.hjwa.org/>.

REFERENCES